THE PIANO BUTLER · LEVEL BOOK

Beginner

Read it like a storybook: one step on each page, a big picture, a few words, and one thing to try at the piano. After each room, a page to practise.

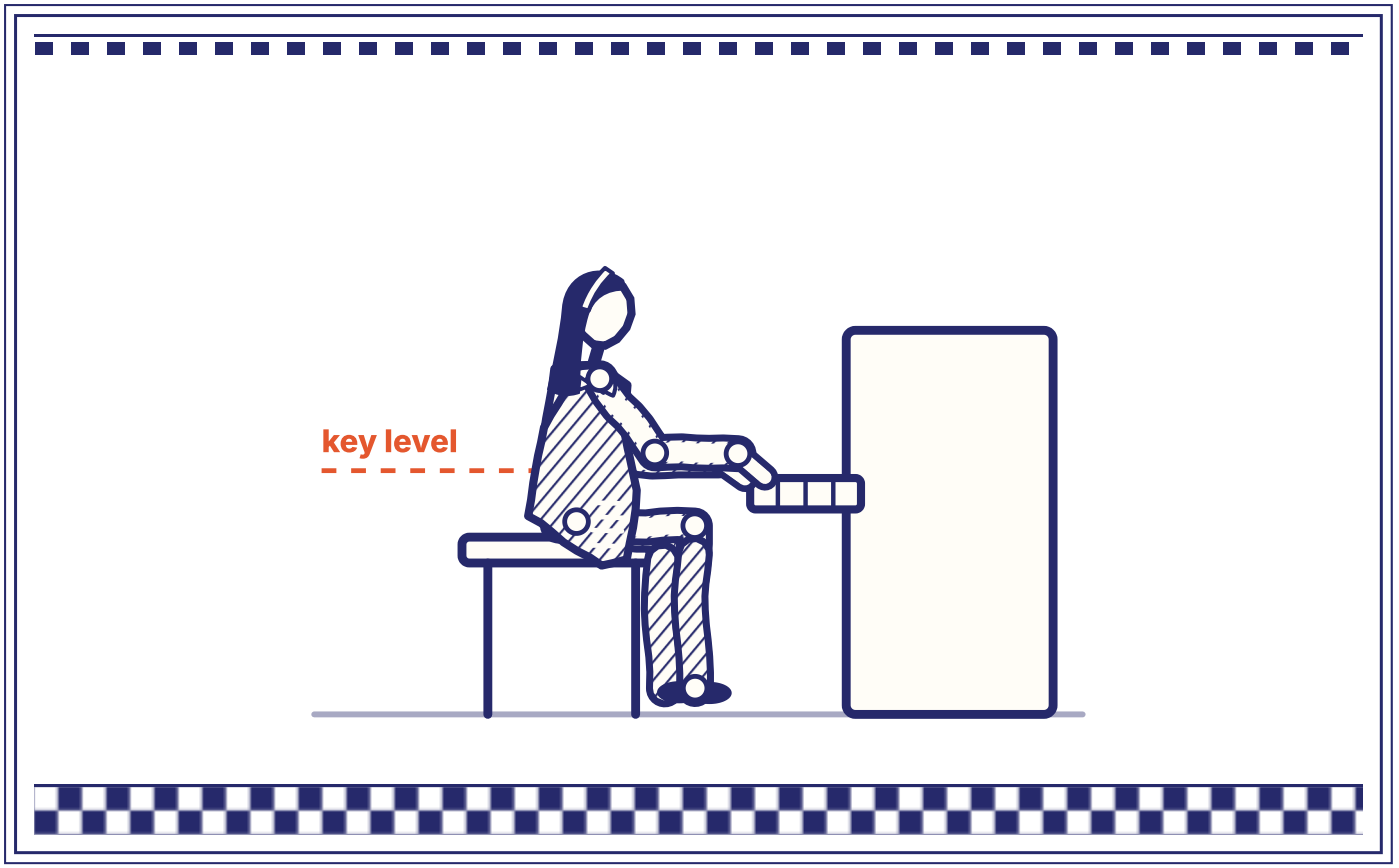
THE ROOMS

1 · Sitting and hands
2 · The keyboard
3 · Finger numbers
4 · The staff and the clefs
5 · The beat
6 · Notes: crotchet and minim
7 · Notes: three beats and four
8 · Loud and soft
9 · Ear training

ROOM 1 · STEP 1 OF 3

Sitting and hands

SCAN TO LISTEN



Sit tall on the front half of the stool, with both **feet flat** on the floor.

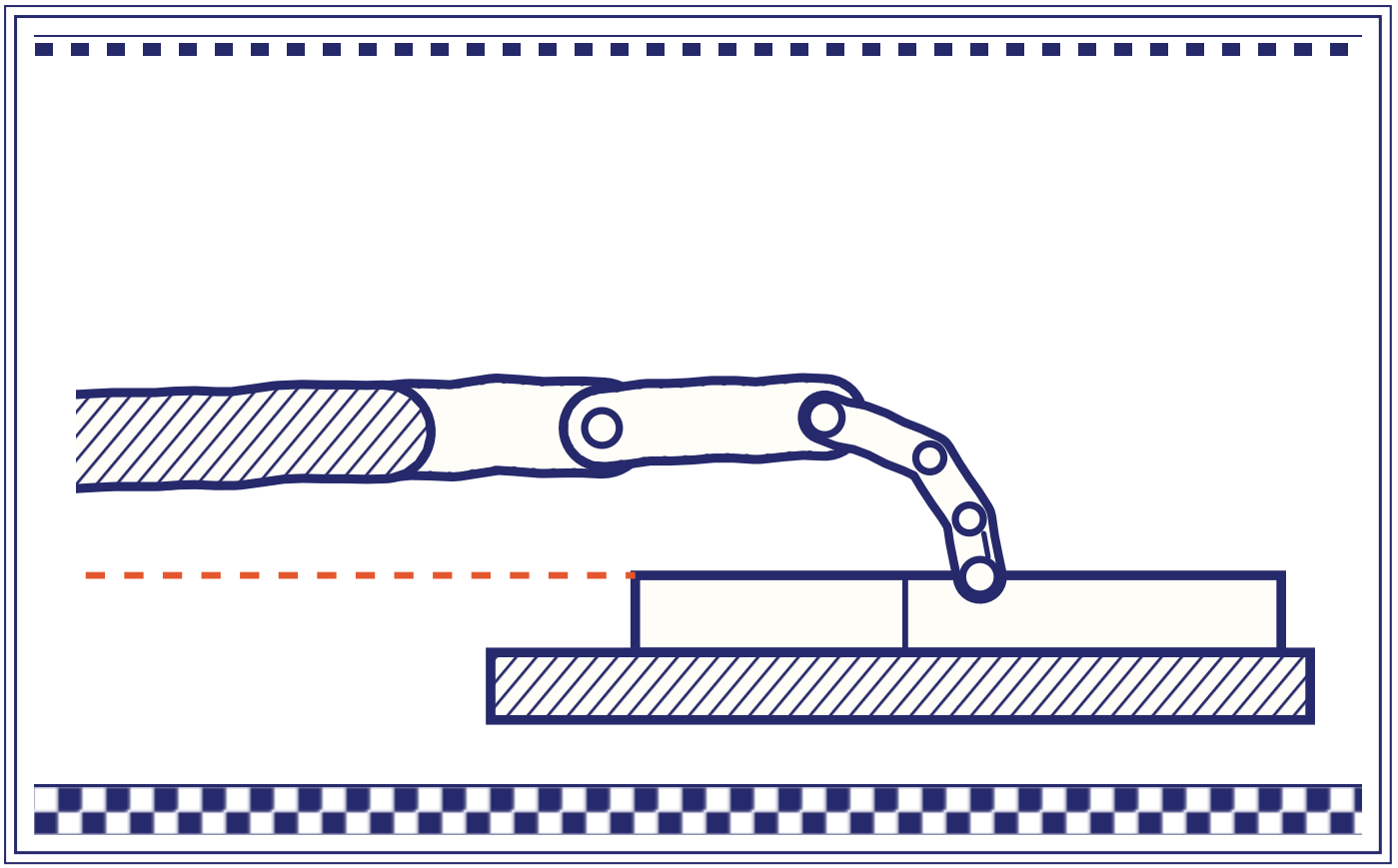
Your arms float out in front, **level with the keys**, like a table top.

At the piano

- [ ] Sit down. Lift your shoulders up to your ears, then let them drop. ◯

ROOM 1 · STEP 2 OF 3

Sitting and hands



Hold a small ball in your hand. That **round shape** is your playing hand.

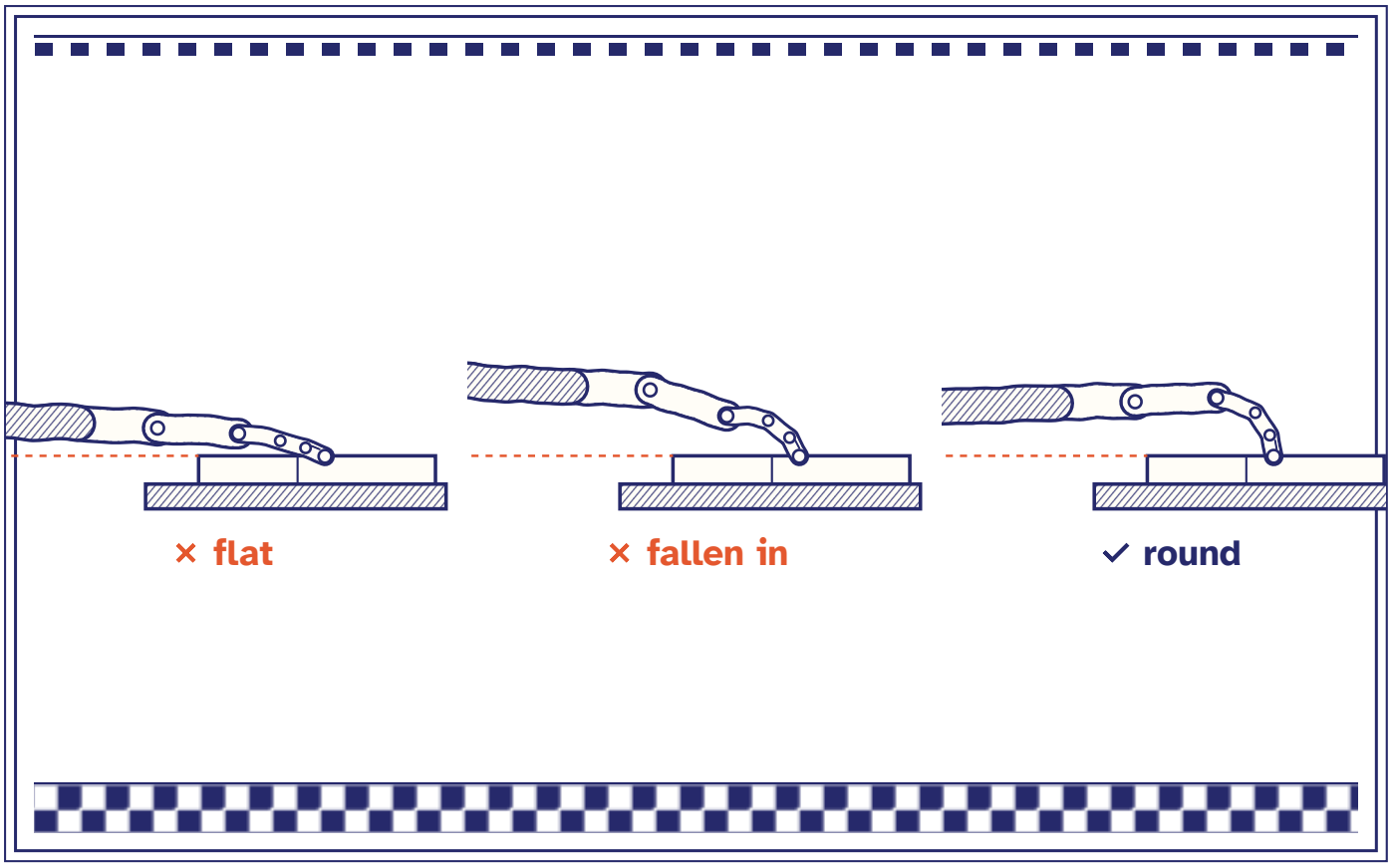
Your knuckles stand up like a **bridge**, and you play on your **fingertips**.

At the piano

- [ ] Hold a ball or an orange. Put your hand on the keys without changing its shape. ◯

ROOM 1 · STEP 3 OF 3

Sitting and hands



A **flat** hand is fast asleep. A bridge that has **fallen in** cannot carry anything.

The **round** hand can play all day.

At the piano

- [ ] Make the flat hand, then the fallen bridge, then the round hand. Feel the difference. ◯

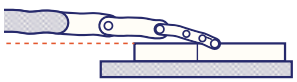
ROOM 1 · PRACTISE

Sitting and hands

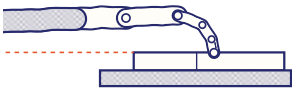
1 Flat, fallen in, or round?

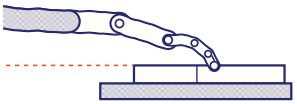
★☆☆

Write the word under each hand. The first is done.



flat





2 Too low, too high, or right?

★★☆

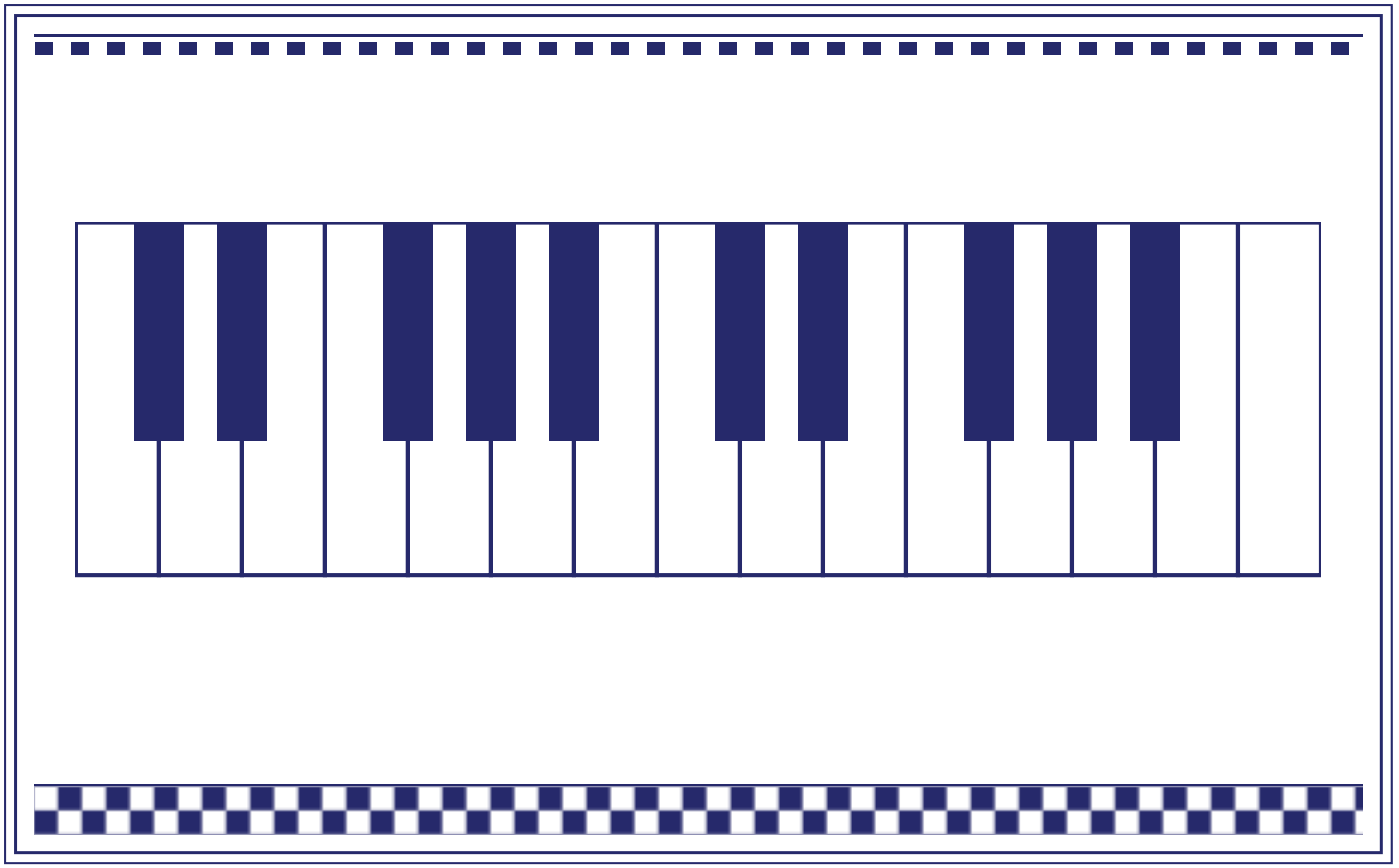
Write too low, too high or right.

WHAT YOU SEE	THE STOOL IS
The elbows are well below the keys; the forearms go uphill.	too low
The forearms are level with the keys.	
The elbows are above the keys; the wrists drop down to them.	

ROOM 2 · STEP 1 OF 3

The keyboard

SCAN TO LISTEN



Look at the black keys. They come in **twos** and **threes**, again and again, all the way along.

Find the pattern once and you can never get lost.

At the piano

- [ ] Touch every group of two black keys, from the left end to the right end. Then every group of three.

ROOM 2 · STEP 2 OF 3

The keyboard



Left is low, like a big grumpy bear. **Right is high**, like a little bird.

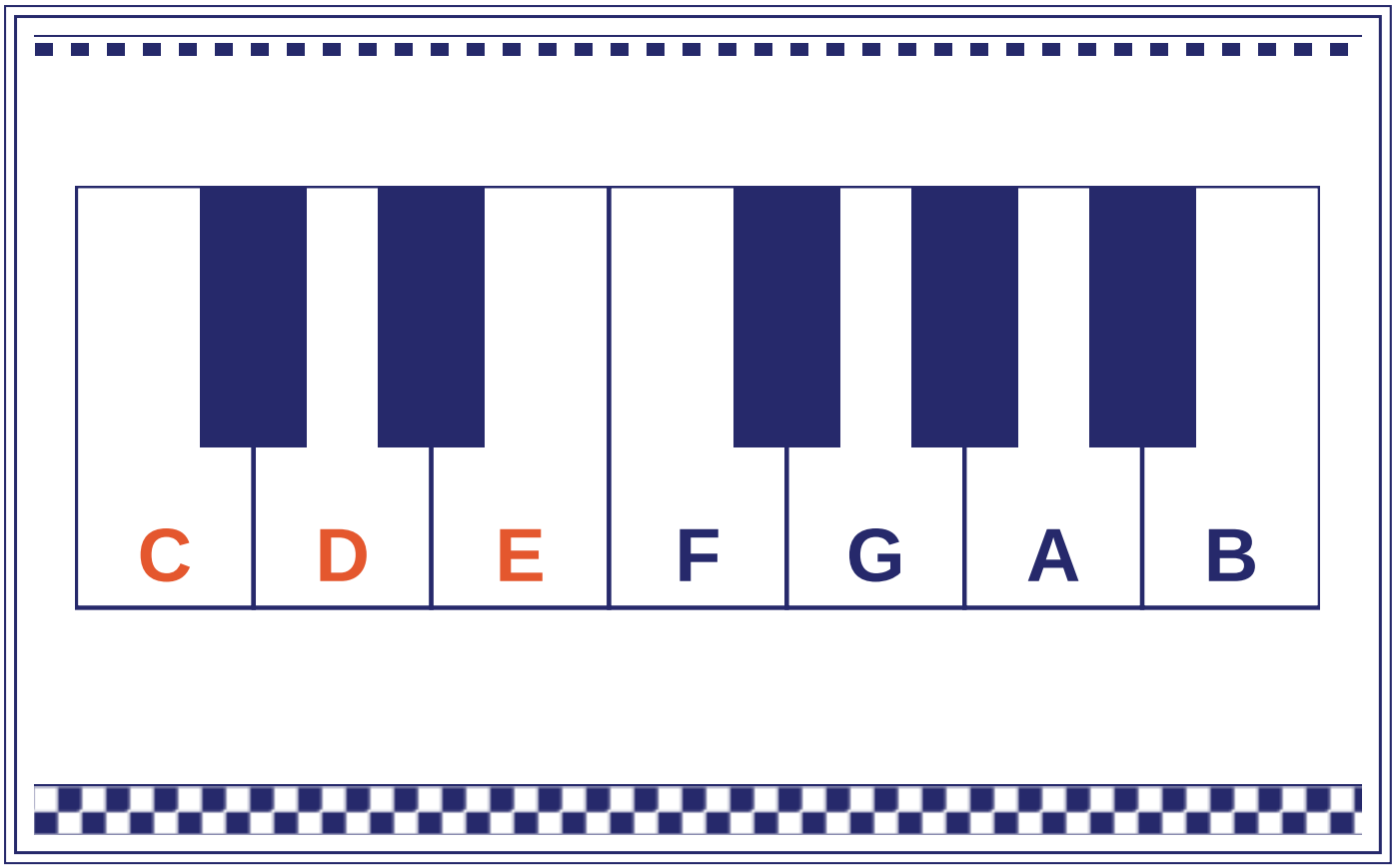
Go to the right and every key sounds a little higher.

At the piano

- [ ] Play the lowest key you can reach, then the highest. Bear, then bird.

ROOM 2 · STEP 3 OF 3

The keyboard



Every white key has a letter. Beside the **two** black keys live **C, D, E**. Beside the **three** live **F, G, A, B**.

After B comes C again: seven letters, round and round.

At the piano

- [ ] Find a group of two black keys. Play the three white keys around it and say C, D, E. ◯

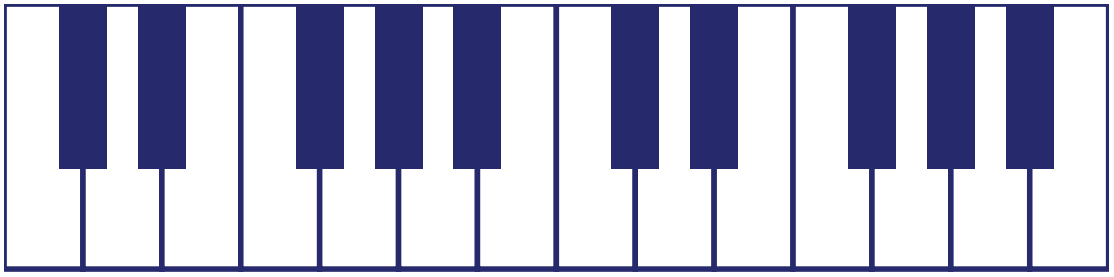
ROOM 2 · PRACTISE

The keyboard

1 Twos and threes

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Circle every group of two black keys. Draw a box round every group of three. How many of each?

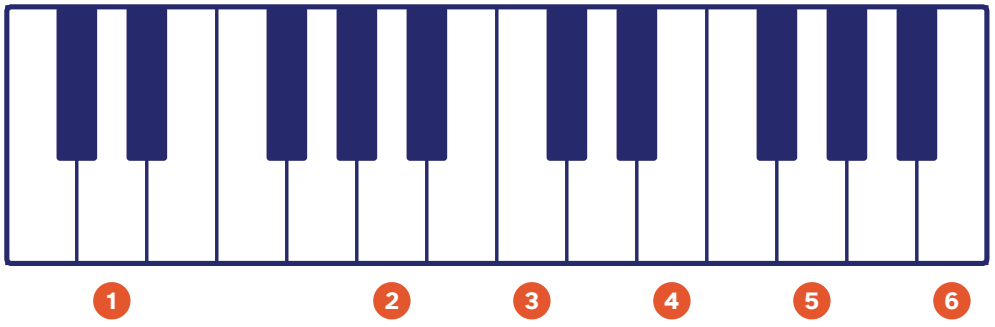


groups of two ☐ groups of three ☐

2 Name the keys

★☆☆

Find the black-key group next to each number. Write the letter of the numbered key. The first is done.

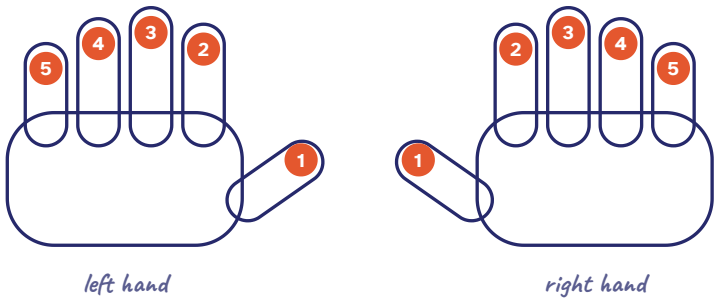


1 D 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐

ROOM 3 · STEP 1 OF 2

Finger numbers

SCAN TO LISTEN



Every finger has a **number**. The **thumb is 1**, then 2, 3, 4, and the little finger is **5**.

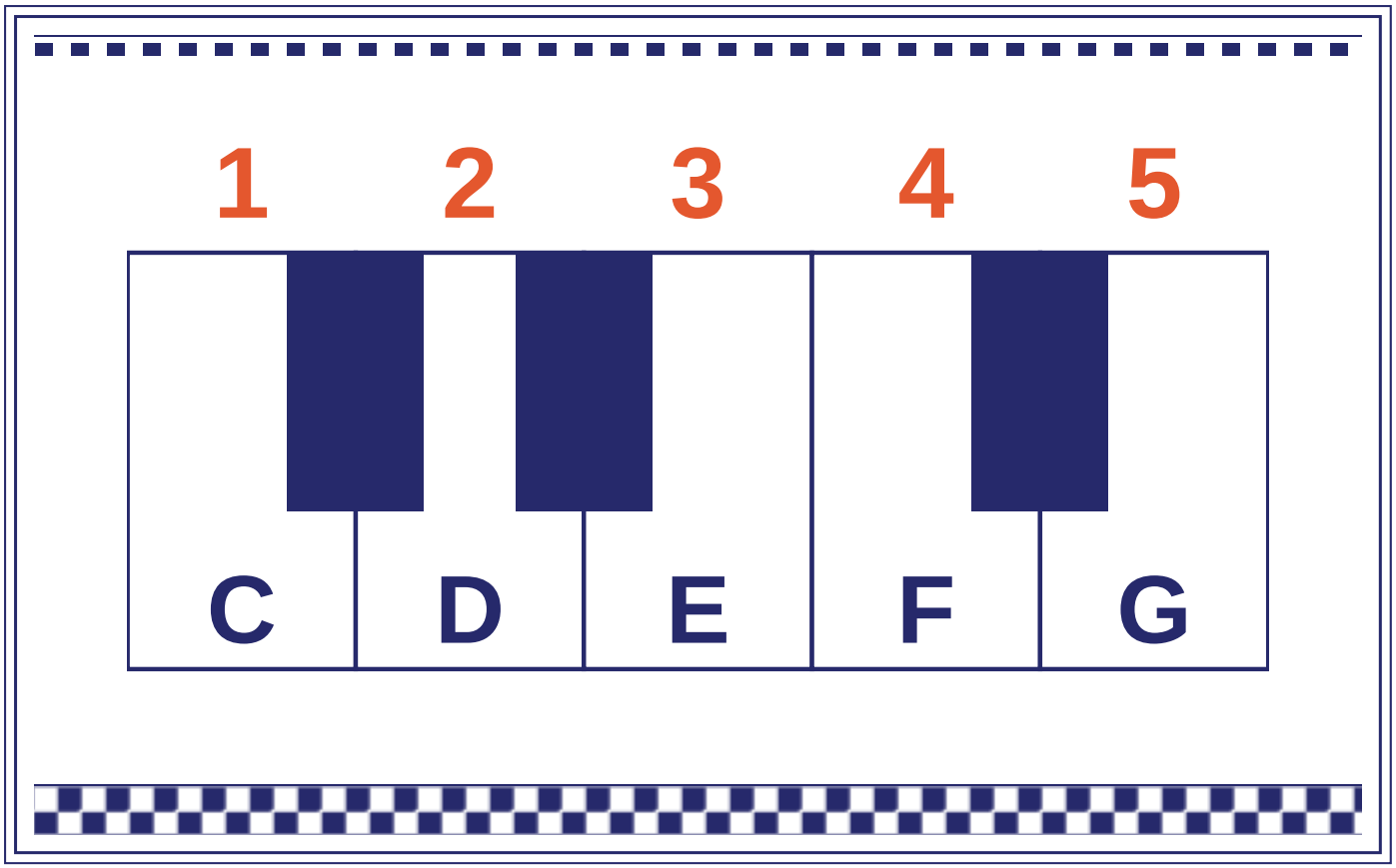
It is the same in both hands: thumbs are always 1.

At the piano

- [ ] Hold up both hands. Wiggle finger 1, then 2, 3, 4, 5, saying the numbers. ◯

ROOM 3 · STEP 2 OF 2

Finger numbers



Find any **C**: the white key just left of two black keys. Put your right thumb on it. Now **C D E F G** are fingers **1 2 3 4 5**.

In the left hand the little finger starts: C D E F G are **5 4 3 2 1**.

At the piano

- [ ] Right thumb on C. Play C D E F G and back, saying the finger numbers. Then the left hand, starting with finger 5. ◯

ROOM 3 · PRACTISE

Finger numbers

1 Finger numbers

★☆☆

Write the number of each finger. They are the same in both hands. The first is done.

FINGER	NUMBER	FINGER	NUMBER
thumb	1	ring finger	
index finger		little finger	
middle finger			

2 Which finger?

★☆☆

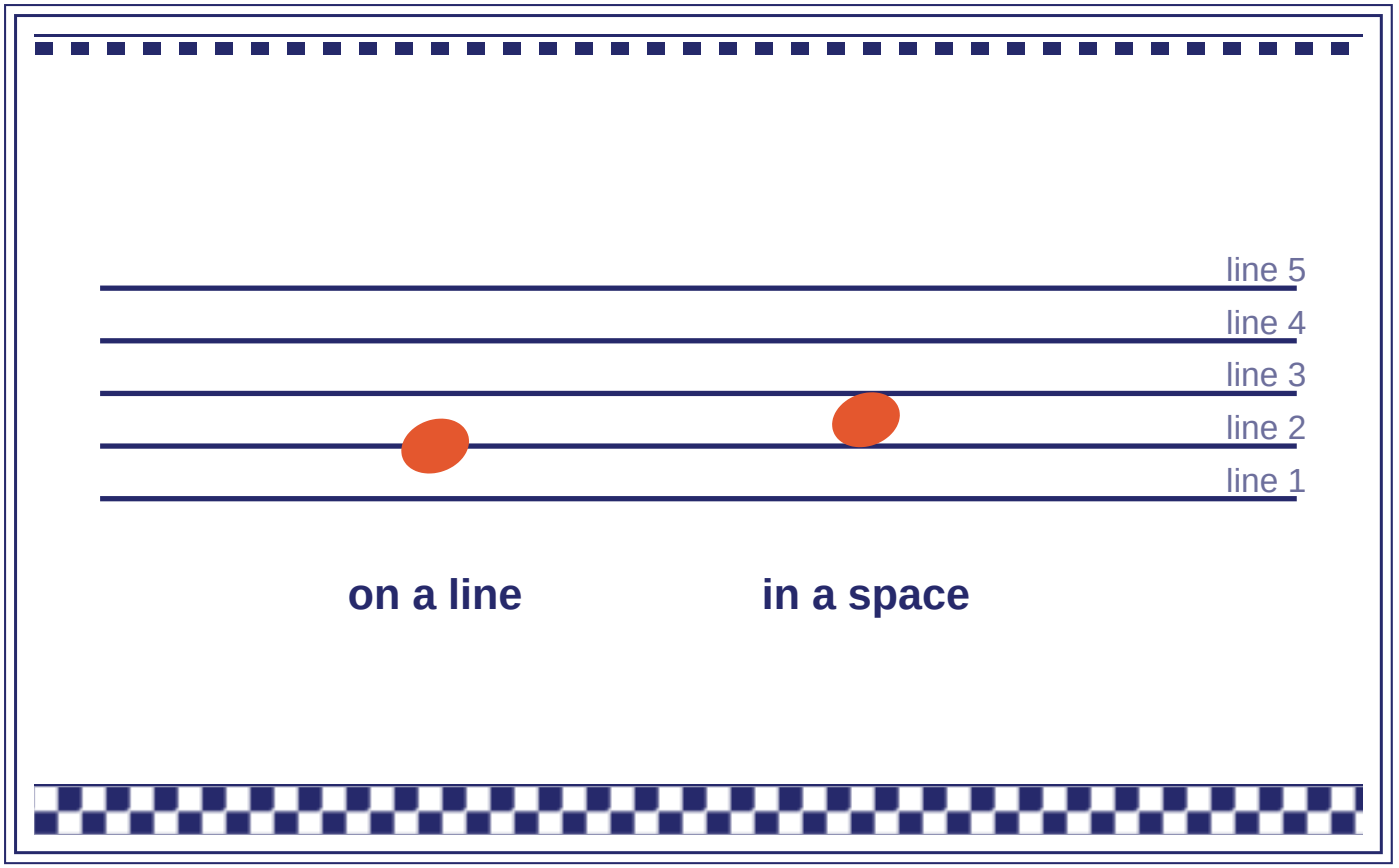
Right hand, thumb on C. Write the finger that plays each note. The first is done.

NOTE	E	G	D	F	C
Finger	3				

ROOM 4 · STEP 1 OF 2

The staff and the clefs

SCAN TO LISTEN



Music is written on **five lines**, called the **staff**.

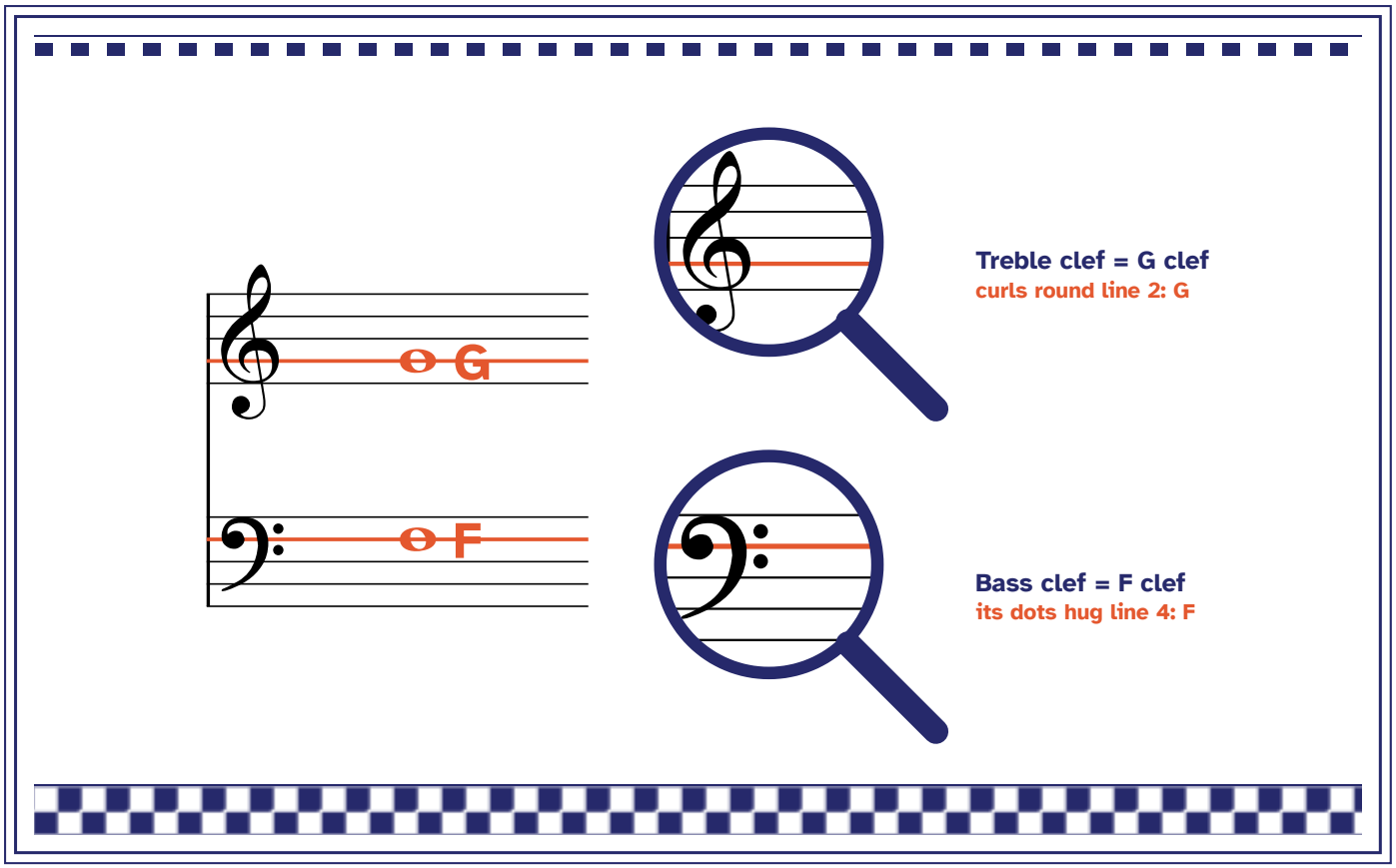
A note can sit **on a line**. Or it can sit **in a space**. Higher up means higher on the piano.

At the piano

- [ ] Count the lines from the bottom: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5. Then count the four spaces. ◯

ROOM 4 · STEP 2 OF 2

The staff and the clefs



A **clef** at the start says which notes the lines stand for.

The **treble clef** is the Queen of the high notes: her curl wraps round the line for **G**. The **bass clef** is the King of the low notes: his two dots hug the line for **F**.

At the piano

- [ ] Play any high key with your right hand: the Queen's side. Then any low key with your left: the King's side. ◯

ROOM 4 · PRACTISE

The staff and the clefs

1 The clefs

★☆☆

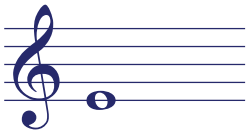
Write the name of each clef and the note it marks.

CLEF	NAME	IT MARKS THE LINE FOR
𝄞		
𝄢		

2 Line or space?

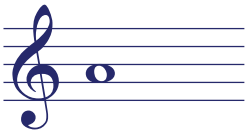
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Circle line or space, then write its number (counted from the bottom). The first is done.

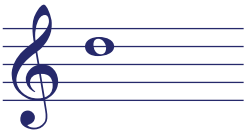


(line) · space

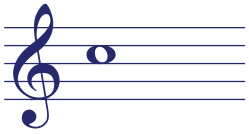
1



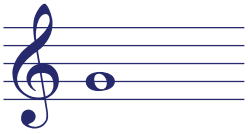
line · space



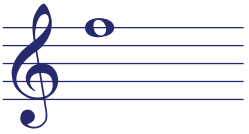
line · space



line · space



line · space

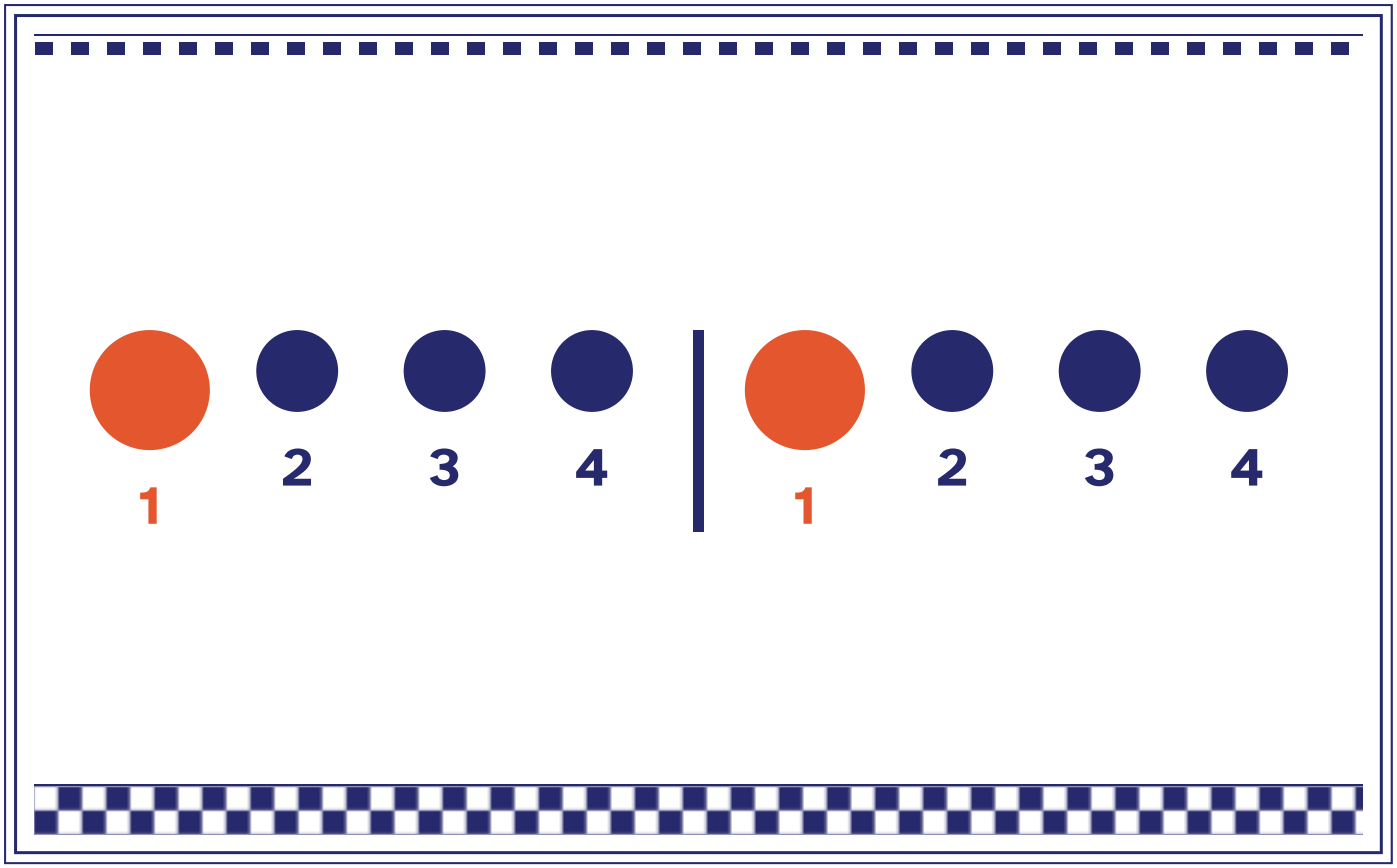


line · space

ROOM 5 · STEP 1 OF 2

The beat

SCAN TO LISTEN



Music has a steady **beat**, like a heartbeat. It never speeds up and never stops.

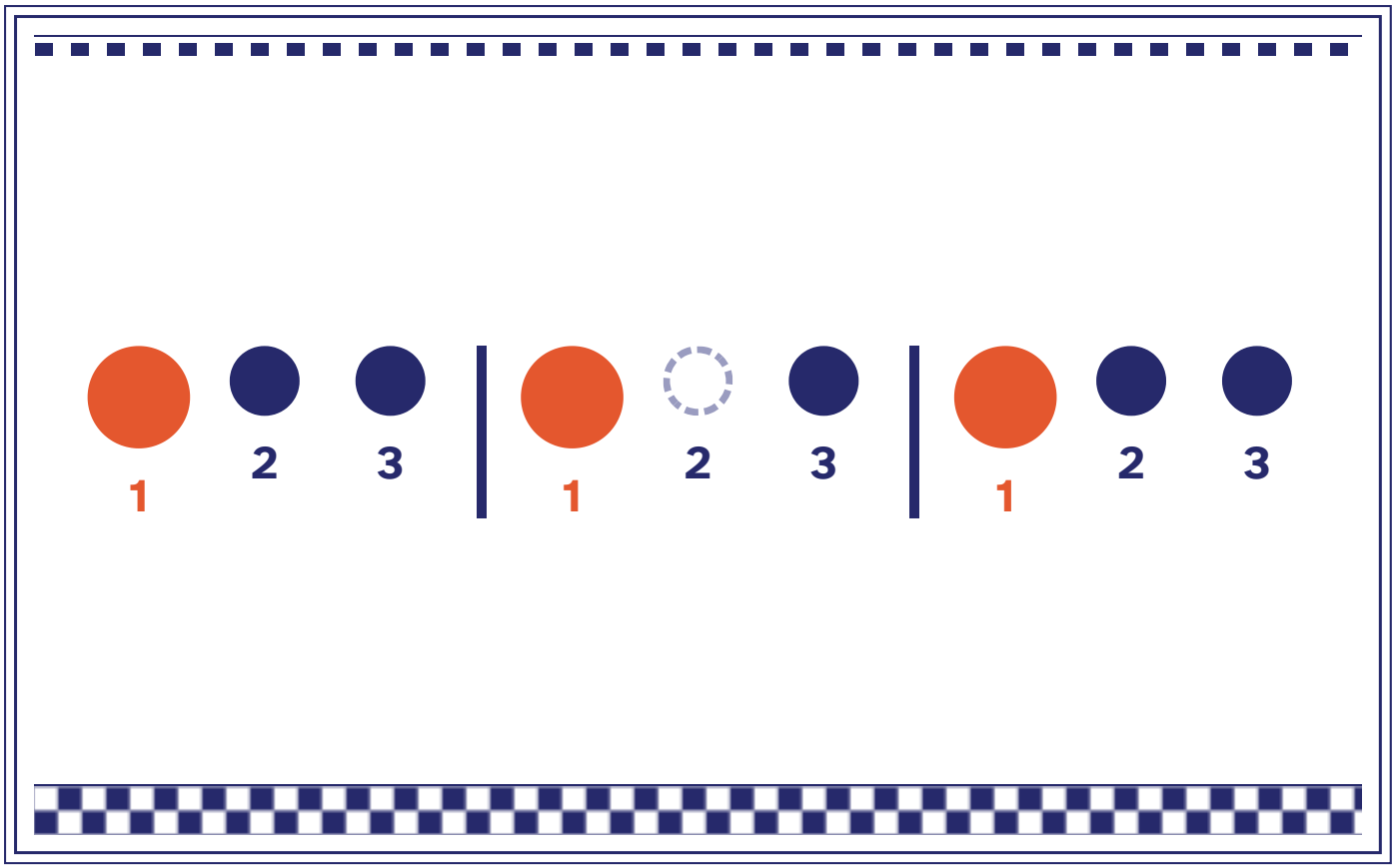
We count the beats: 1, 2, 3, 4, and round again.

At the piano

- [ ] Put a hand on your heart. Tap that steady beat on your knee and count 1 2 3 4.

ROOM 5 · STEP 2 OF 2

The beat



Bar lines put the beats into groups called **bars**. **Beat 1** of every bar is the strongest.

Sometimes a beat is **silent**. You still count it.

At the piano

- [ ] Clap three in a bar: STRONG, weak, weak. Then leave out one clap, but keep counting. ○

ROOM 5 · PRACTISE

The beat

1 How many beats in each bar?

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Count the dots between the bar lines. The first is done.



3







2 Add the bar lines

★★☆

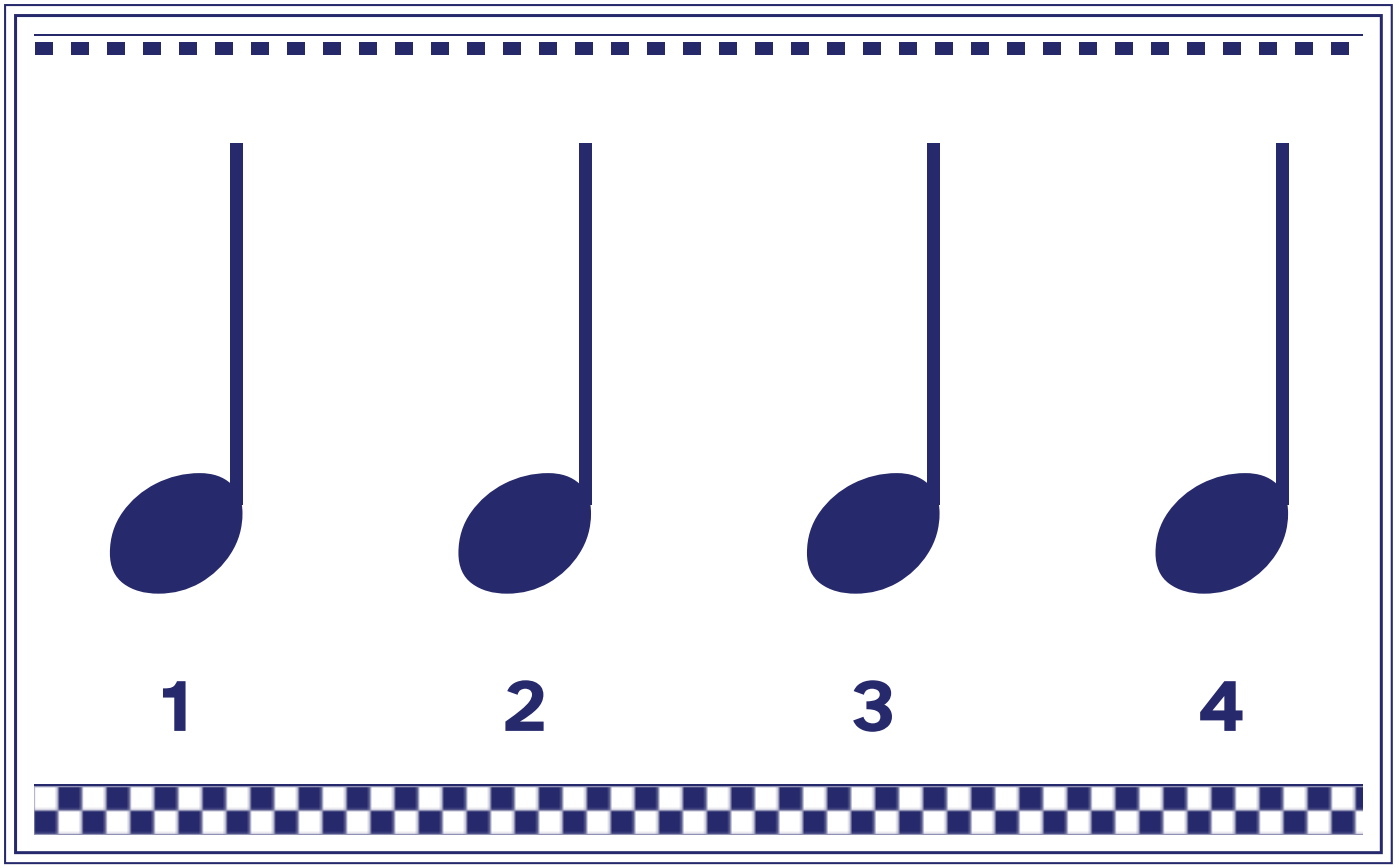
Beat 1 is the big coral dot. Draw a bar line just before each one (the first is done).



ROOM 6 · STEP 1 OF 3

Notes: crotchet and minim

SCAN TO LISTEN



This is a **crotchet**. It lasts **one beat**.

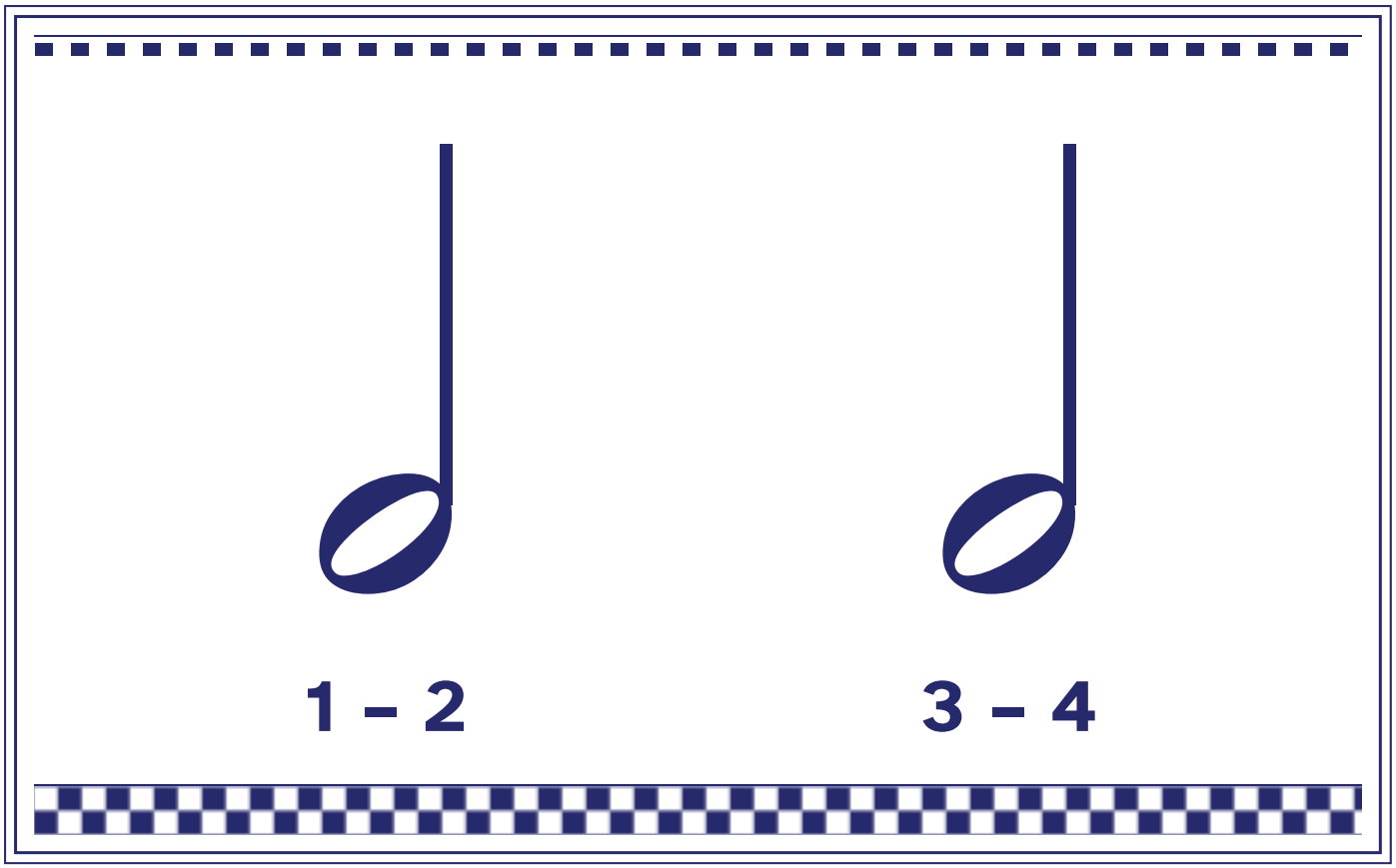
Four crotchets fill a bar of four: play, play, play, play.

At the piano

- [ ] Play C four times, one for each beat, counting 1 2 3 4. ◯

ROOM 6 · STEP 2 OF 3

Notes: crotchet and minim



This is a **minim**. Its head is empty, and it lasts **two beats**.

Play on the first beat and **hold** through the second.

At the piano

- [ ] Play C as a minim: press on 1, hold through 2. Then again on 3, holding through 4. ◯

ROOM 6 · STEP 3 OF 3

Notes: crotchet and minim



Silence has signs too, called **rests**. A **crotchet rest** is one beat of silence.

You count a rest just like a note. You just do not play.

At the piano

- [ ] Play, shh, play, shh: C on beats 1 and 3, silence on 2 and 4. Keep counting. ◯

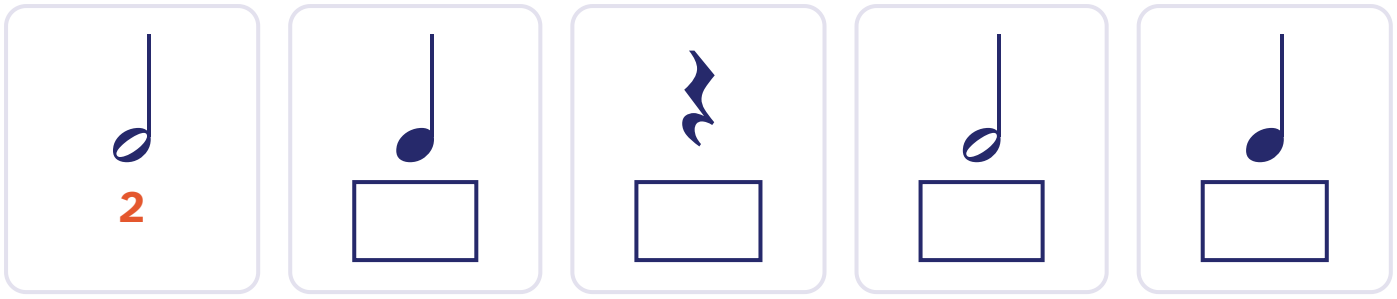
ROOM 6 · PRACTISE

Notes: crotchet and minim

1 One beat or two?

★☆☆

Write 1 or 2 under each. The first is done.



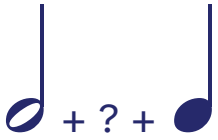
2 Fill the bar

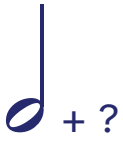
★★☆

Four beats in each bar. Write the missing note: crotchet or minim. The first is done.



minim

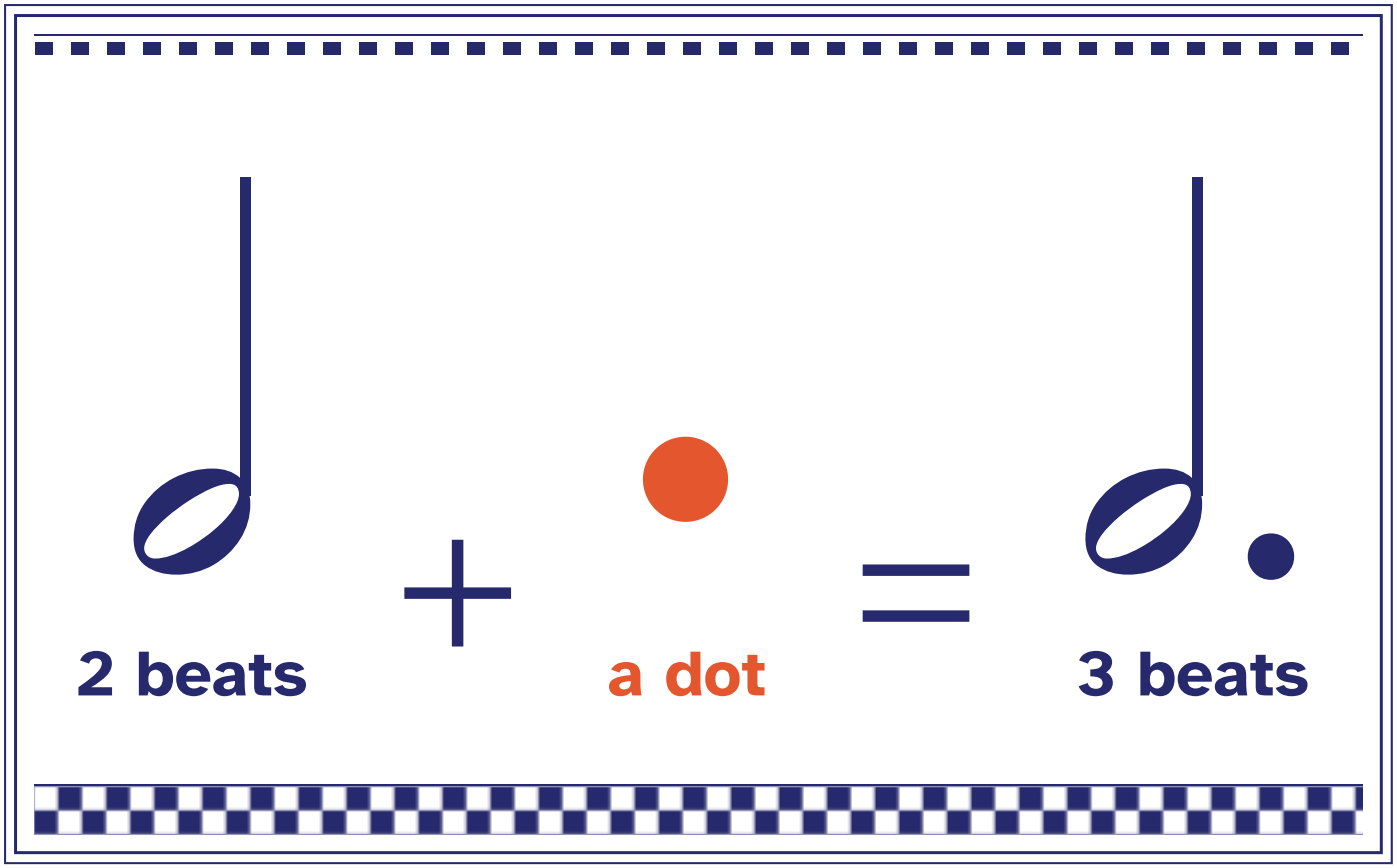




ROOM 7 · STEP 1 OF 3

Notes: three beats and four

SCAN TO LISTEN



A **dot** after a minim adds one more beat.

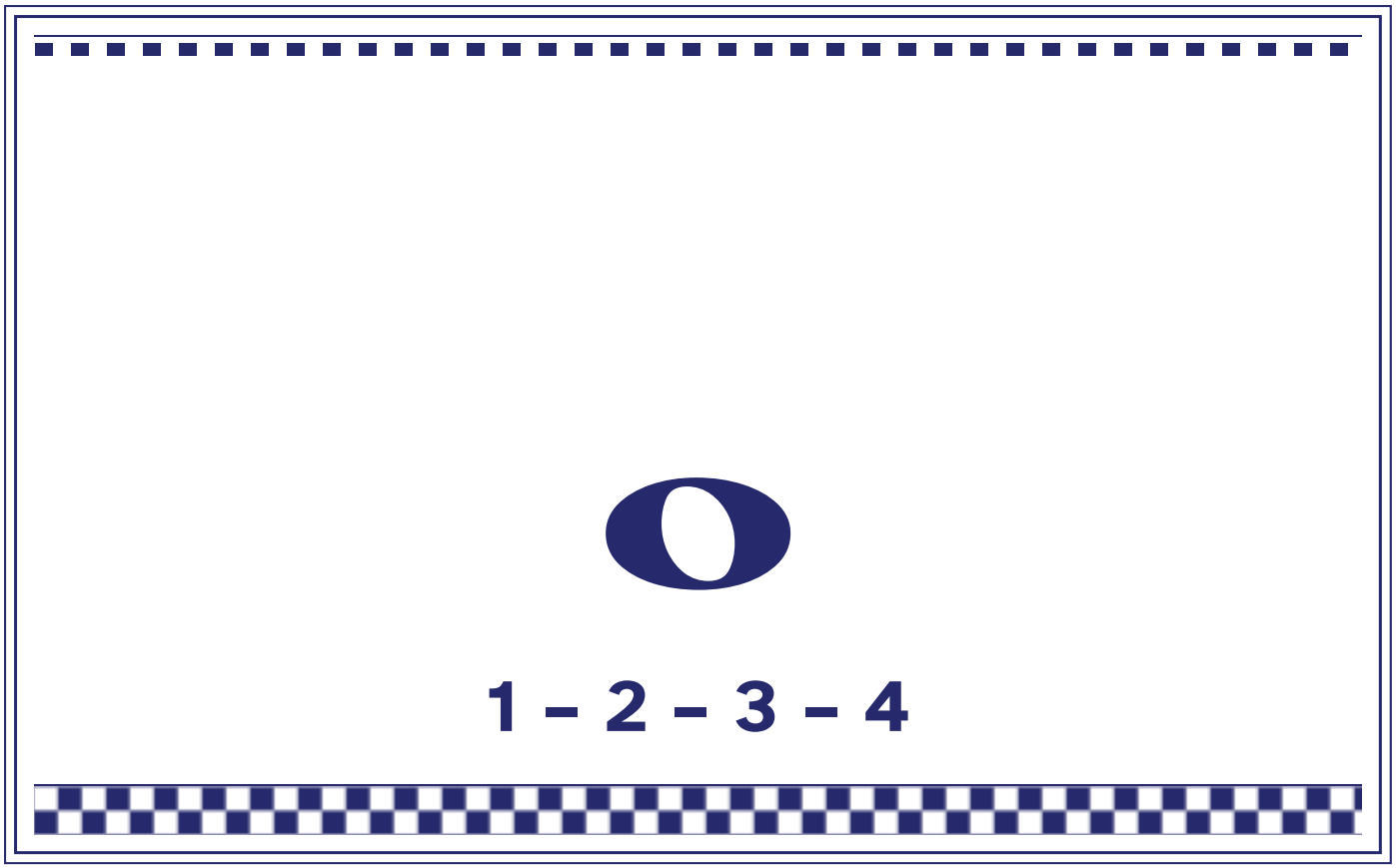
Two beats and one more: a **dotted minim** lasts **three beats**.

At the piano

- [ ] Play C and hold for 1 2 3. Lean in on beat 1. ○

ROOM 7 · STEP 2 OF 3

Notes: three beats and four



This is a **semibreve**: an empty head and no stem. It lasts **four beats**, a whole bar of four.

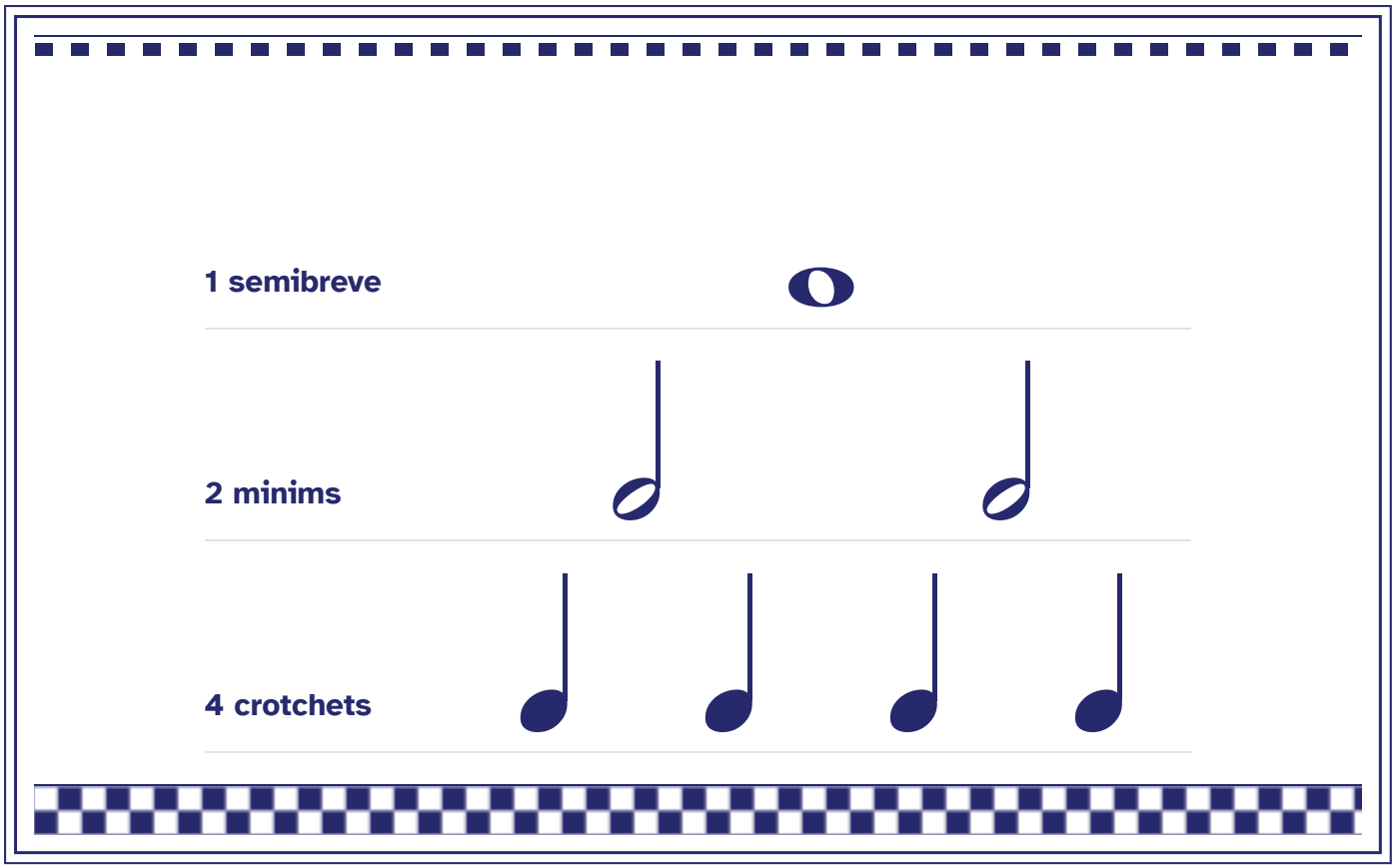
Press once, and listen until the sound has had all four beats.

At the piano

- [ ] Play C and hold for 1 2 3 4. Lift exactly when the next bar begins. ◯

ROOM 7 · STEP 3 OF 3

Notes: three beats and four



Now you know the family. Each note is **half** of the one above it.

One semibreve is as long as two minims, or four crotchets.

At the piano

- [ ] Play four crotchets on C. Then one semibreve, held for all four beats. The same length! ○

ROOM 7 · PRACTISE

Notes: three beats and four

1 Name and beats

★☆☆

Fill in the table. The first row is done.

NOTE	NAME	BEATS
	semibreve	4
	_____	☐
	_____	☐
	_____	☐

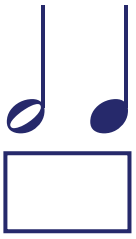
2 Three in a bar

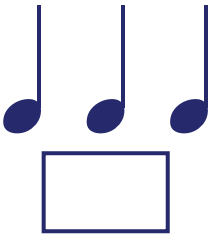
★★☆

Each bar has three beats. Count 1 2 3 and play each bar. Write how many notes it has. The first is done.



1

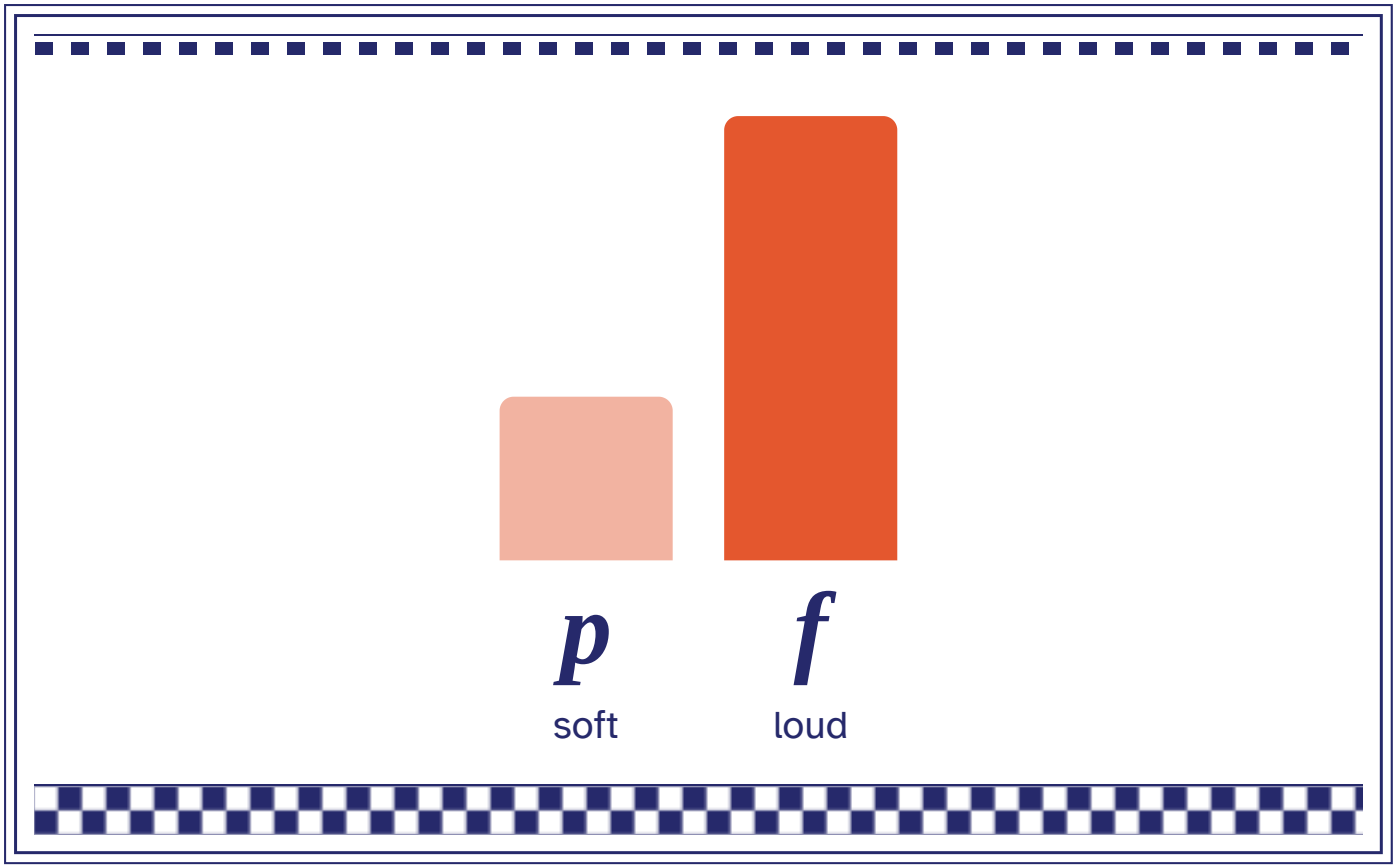




ROOM 8 · STEP 1 OF 2

Loud and soft

SCAN TO LISTEN



Music can be **soft** or **loud**. The signs are Italian: ***p*** for *piano*, soft, and ***f*** for *forte*, loud.

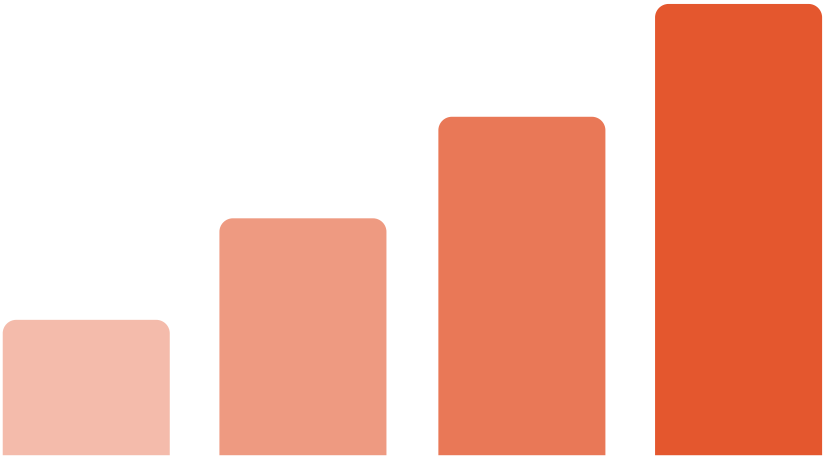
To play louder, let your arm feel heavy. Do not hit the key.

At the piano

- [ ] Play C softly, like a secret. Then play it loudly, like calling across a field.

ROOM 8 · STEP 2 OF 2

Loud and soft



In between come two more. The ***m*** is for *mezzo*, which means **half** or **medium**: ***mp*** is quite soft, ***mf*** is quite loud.

Soft does not mean slow, and loud does not mean fast. The beat stays the same.

At the piano

- [ ] Play C four times: p, mp, mf, f. Four steps, the same speed. ◯

ROOM 8 · PRACTISE

Loud and soft

1 What does it mean?

★☆☆

Write soft, loud, quite soft or quite loud. The first is done.

SIGN	MEANS
p	soft
f	
mp	
mf	

2 Play it

★☆☆

Play C four times: p, mp, mf, f. Four steps, the same speed. Tick a circle each day.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

ROOM 9 · STEP 1 OF 1

Ear training

SCAN TO PLAY

1. **Low, middle or high?**
2. **Same clapping, or different?**
3. **Same tune, or different?**
4. **Which way did it go?**
5. **Find the note**

Listen first, then play. Good ears make good fingers.

Five listening games are waiting in the app. Scan the code and play one each day.

At the piano

- [ ] Before you play a note, sing it. Then play it and listen: were you right? ◯

ROOM 9 · PRACTISE

Ear training

1 Floor, tummy or sky?

★☆☆

A grown-up plays one key: very low, in the middle, or very high. Eyes closed! Point to the floor, your tummy or the sky.

2 Copy-cat clap

★☆☆

A grown-up claps a short pattern. Clap it back exactly. Then swap: you clap, they copy.